Q+A

Down to the Bone

Nawazuddin Siddiqui flexes his talents again, playing a transgender person in his latest role in the film *Haddi*

Q. ZEE5's *Haddi* isn't the first time a male actor has played a transgender character. What's different?
To be honest, *Haddi* isn't just about whether one is able to portray the physicality of a transgender. It is more about portraying the inner world of transgender.... Yes, we have had transgender characters in a lot of films, but mostly on the fringes, as subjects of ridicule, or as mere lip service. *Haddi* was difficult for me because I had all these things in mind.

Q. Would you like to elaborate on the challenges you faced?
The character was not just intense, but also painful. The prep of living with transgenders was something I was looking forward to. But once I did that, every single day was a war in my mind. I realised that the only desire a transgender has is to become a woman. This meant I had to be *Haddi* as a woman, and not as a transgender.

Q. You have maintained that you are stubborn about your growth as an actor. What more do you aspire to do?
The experimentation will never stop, regardless of the budget or canvas of the film. I want to be able to portray all aspects of life, of me. Pushing the envelope and complete honesty in the way I portray a character are important to me. And I'll be stubborn in aspiring to work like this.

Q. Do your forthcoming films help you do that?
Most certainly! I have *Adbhut*, *Bole Chudiyan*, and *Noorani Chehra* in the pipeline—and each one has a different me in them! And that is what keeps me excited. I am also looking forward to my first Telugu film, *Saindhav*, with Daggubati Venkatesh.

with Aarti Kapur Singh



Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**